

Mak Trnka

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Croatia Defense Policy

Croatia, a country located in the Balkans, current NATO member since 2009, and recent member of EU in 2013, is facing certain issues on having the capability to modernize their Croatian Armed and Air Forces and most of the equipment remains outdated. Ever since the war in the Balkans ended, the country has reduced several of their military procedures and when the financial crisis in 2008 hit, it has hampered Croatia from deciding to increase their defense budget and thwarted the ability to put in place modernization programs at the right time. Croatia has not been able to reach its goals since 2015, due to the consequences caused by the financial crisis and high national debt, meaning there is still long ways to go till Croatia has as modernized and up to date armed and air forces as most of its NATO members, so they can be included and deployed in many more missions at home and abroad, and stop having a shrinkage in military personnel on the ground. In 2008 the number of military personnel was 22,000, in 2013 it was 19,600, and in 2018 it is about 18,525. Croatia will make sure to invest in its defense capabilities and work with other countries to ensure they have a well modernized military. NATO's requirements have encouraged Croatia to strengthen military capabilities.

Priorities

Croatia is focused on trying to modernize its armed and air forces, speed up the process of doing it all, following NATO's encouragement to strengthen their force, trying to have as competent and strong of a military as other major NATO members. Major initiatives such as the Croatian Armed Forces Long-Term Development Plan (LTDP) has been launched in 2015 which calls for Croatia to improving its military strength, develop reliable collaboration with UN missions and the Council Security Defense Policy (CSDP), create armed forces based on social accountability, and especially strengthen the competence to put in place non-military tasks both at home and abroad. In addition, in order for Croatia to be well integrated with NATO's own surveillance capabilities, it is trying to work hard on developing their maritime surveillance sensor data.^[1]

Current Status

Croatia has only been working with the U.S. so far to provide itself with modernized and up to date weaponry, training, and funding. The two countries have agreed so far that the U.S. will deliver as many missiles as possible to Croatia till 2020 which costed about €2.7 billion. For example, since 2016, U.S. donated about sixteen Bell OH-58 D Kiowa Warrior Helicopters to Croatia and the government accepted to buy AGM-114 Hellfire missiles. Also, when it comes to replacing equipment to more modernized and up-to-date ones, Croatia has agreed to purchase twelve used D-16D 'Barak' fighter jets from Israel which would be €430 million, used to replace the old MiG-21s from Russia and will be delivered 2021.^[1] Lastly, the capital of Zagreb has outlined plans to boost their defense budget in order to meet NATO's two percent of gross domestic product threshold by 2024.^[2]

Policy Options

a) Demand, encourage, and negotiate with members of the EU or NATO, not just the U.S. or Israel, to provide more modernized and up-to-date military equipment to us (Other countries may not be satisfied in providing us with weaponry unless we provide any of our weaponry back, which could make us lose our valuable equipment. However, it would be a great way to help us replace any outdated military equipment in order to for us to have a more modernized military for the future).

b) Have Croatia's defense industries sign an agreement with other current NATO member's defense industries in order to offer assistance and support to each other's defense industries in the use of available EU defense funds (The most modernized military forces in NATO may not be interested in signing any agreement with us, unless we were already as modernized as them, which means only another not so modernized military country might only be interested in signing a deal, which might make it slower for us to advance our forces. However, this could be a great way to improve our alliances and make our presence in NATO stronger).

c) Pressure the EU defense fund to double the size of Croatia's defense forces, letting NATO know that Croatia will fully integrate with NATO's military capabilities and expand their missions once the money arrives (EU defense fund might not be willing to increase their funds by that much if its too costly to them, but this could be just a good way to advance our military even quicker).

Policy Recommendation

The Foreign Ministry of Croatia recommends policy option a) 'Sign a Defense Industry agreement with other NATO members in the use of available EU defense funds'. We feel that if we want to modernize our military and work more closely with our NATO allies, it would be best to sign an agreement with certain NATO members, connecting their defense industries, it will help exchange business experiences on foreign markets, transfer new technologies to each other, opening up opportunities for the expansion of innovative systems that could be funded by the European Defense Funds. Croatia demands the European Defense Fund to have €13 Billion be submitted to the Council at their next budgetary meeting once opportunities open up for the development of advanced innovative systems (There could be few barriers under this option for sure. Perhaps barley any strong member of NATO would be interested in signing any agreement with us when it comes to having our defensive industries cooperating, since they could consider us weak due to us not having as modernized of a military yet. However, if this gets done, especially with more than just two countries, it could make our alliance with NATO and EU stronger and our military will be more capable and modernized than ever to increase NATO's presence and power abroad, helping bring a successful end to any missions at home and abroad).

Budget

€13 billion annually for the next 5 years, totaling €65b. This money will go to expanding and modernizing the Croatian Army, Navy and Air Force, along with whoever joins the defense industry agreement, including the purchase of new tanks, submarines with the improvement of surveillance, drones, and up-to date helicopters, along with new training equipment. There are several ways we plan to fund this, as long as there are proposals that could be made in order to not increase our debt any further.

Sources:

<https://www.total-croatia-news.com/business/56394-croatian-slovenian-consortium> [1]

[file:///C:/Users/maktr/Downloads/Current Defence Policy and Modernization.pdf](file:///C:/Users/maktr/Downloads/Current%20Defence%20Policy%20and%20Modernization.pdf) [2]